THE FRENCH WARS

THE AMBITIONS OF French King Louis XIV generated a series of wars in which to test his freshly expanded navy. After England made peace with France in 1674, Louis remained at war with the Dutch, who allied themselves with their former enemies the Spanish. A series of sharp sea battles were fought in the Mediterranean, which ended in a notable success for the French navy under Admiral Duquesne. However, the War of the League of Augsburg (1688-97) brought France into conflict with England, which was supported by the Dutch, now fielding a distinctly inferior naval force. An early victory at Beachy Head, under the excellent Admiral de Tourville, gave the French navy command of the sea, but this was soon reversed by a disastrous defeat at the twin battles of Barfleur and La Hogue. For the rest of the war, and through the subsequent War of the Spanish Succession (1701-14), the French made no further serious attempt to contest the dominance of the English fleet, although France's seamen demonstrated their skill and boldness in commerce-raiding and other small-scale actions.

FRANCO-DUTCH WAR

ALICUDI



Date January 6, 1676
Forces Dutch and Spanish: 19 ships of the line; French: 20 ships of the line
Losses Dutch and Spanish: 1 ship; French: none

Location
Aeolian islands, Sicily

In 1674 the people of Messina in Sicily rose up in revolt against Spanish rule and invited the French to come to their aid. King Louis XIV sent a squadron to Messina, installing a viceroy to rule the island. When the Spanish fleet attempted to intercept a troop convoy sent to Sicily in February 1675, it was roundly defeated off Stromboli. The Spanish called on the Dutch for help and Dutch Admiral Michiel de Ruyter was sent with a weak squadron of 18 ships to link up with the Spanish fleet. He found Spain in a hapless state of disorganization, however, and sailed for Sicily with only a single Spanish ship of the line to augment his squadron, plus a handful of galleys.

De Ruyter encountered a French force under Admiral Duquesne off the island of Alicudi. The French had a similar number of ships but far superior firepower and de Ruyter was reluctant to give battle, but once the wind shifted to Duquesne's advantage the French attacked. Approaching the Dutch line obliquely, the French van took a pounding and several ships were forced to withdraw. Nonetheless, once the two lines were closely engaged the French guns did their work. After six hours the fighting ceased. The Spanish galleys towed off the most badly damaged Dutch ships, one of which sank during the night. The French had suffered the heavier casualties, however, in a thoroughly inconclusive encounter.

> "THE DUTCH FLEET UNDER DE RUYTER CAN ENTER A MOONLESS NIGHT IN HEAVY WIND AND FOG AND EMERGE THE NEXT DAY IN PERFECT LINE AHEAD."
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> **FRENCH ADMIRAL ABRAHAM DUQUESNE**, REPORT TO KING LOUIS XIV, 1676

FRANCO-DUTCH WAR

AGOSTA



Date April 22, 1676
Forces Dutch and Spanish: 27 ships of the line; French: 29 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Off Agosta, eastern Sicily

After the battle of Alicudi, Michiel de Ruyter's Dutch squadron was belatedly joined by a further eight Spanish ships under Admiral Don Francisco de la Cerda. Admiral Duquesne entered Messina. The total French strength still exceeded that of the combined Spanish and Dutch fleet, but they allowed themselves to be blockaded in harbor by de Ruyter, so little confidence did they have in their ability to defeat the legendary Dutch admiral.

In April, despairing of the French ever coming out, the Spanish and Dutch sailed to threaten the French-controlled harbor of Agosta. Duquesne felt bound to respond and the two fleets met on April 22. The haughty Admiral de la Cerda insisted on being recognized as overall commander of the combined fleet and thus holding the position of honour in the center of the line. He also insisted that his Spanish squadron remain together under his command. Thus the Dutch were split, de Ruyter leading half of their ships in the van and the rest of the Dutch ships making up the rear division.

Eendracht
The Dutch ship *Eendracht* was de Ruyter's flagship at Agosta when the admiral was mortally wounded by the French guns.



De Ruyter closely engaged the French van, but the Spanish held off, limiting themselves to some token long-range exchanges with the French center. The Dutch in the rear, under Admiral den Haen, mostly focused on the Spanish, although they did succeed in engaging the rearmost French ships. At first the Dutch van had the better of the fighting, but once Duquesne realized the Spanish were not going to fight he began moving ships forward from his center. Isolated and outgunned, the Dutch van suffered grievously. De Ruyter was wounded in the leg, and his flagship was shattered.

Both sides were happy to break off the fight at the end of the day. De Ruyter died a week later of gangrene; a sad end for an admiral who deserved to fall in a more distinguished combat.

FRANCO-DUTCH WAR

PALERMO



Date June 2, 1676
Forces Dutch and Spanish: 27 ships of the line; French: 28 ships of the line
Losses Dutch and Spanish: 7 ships; French: none

Location
Palermo, Sicily

The combined Dutch and Spanish fleet was in poor shape after the battle of Agosta. Demoralized by the loss of Admiral de Ruyter, they anchored in a defensive line across Palermo Harbor. The French, largely at the inspiration of the Comte de Tourville, conceived a bold plan of attack. The Marquis de Preuilly took nine ships to attack one end of the enemy line at close quarters. The rest of the French fleet maintained a barrage from longer range while sending fireships down on the harbor.

In panic the Dutch and Spanish ships cut their cables, drifting into shore. Three Dutch ships and four Spanish ships were destroyed by fire, including both flagships. Satisfied with this triumph, the French fleet subsequently withdrew from Sicily, allowing the island to return to Spanish rule.

Matchlock musket
Muskets were brought to bear when ships came within 220 yards (200 m) or so of each other. Matchlocks remained in use in Europe until about 1700.

